

THE CALM PARENT SERIES

Parenting the Anxious Child

*Calm Strategies for the Child Who
Worries Too Much*

Disclaimer

This book is intended for educational and informational purposes only. Parenting involves highly individual circumstances, and what works for one child and family may not work for another.

Nothing in this book constitutes medical, psychological, or professional parenting advice. For children with diagnosed developmental, behavioral, or mental health conditions, please consult qualified professionals.

The author and publisher do not claim any specific parenting outcomes from the practices described. Always trust your knowledge of your own child and consult professionals when in doubt.

Contents

1. Anxiety in Children Is Common and Treatable
2. The Parent's Role in Anxiety Treatment
3. The Anxious Child at School
4. What Anxious Kids Need to Hear
5. Handling Reassurance Seeking
6. When to Get Professional Help

Anxiety in Children Is Common and Treatable

Anxiety disorders are the most common childhood mental health condition. They also have some of the most effective treatments.

The Prevalence and the Path

Approximately 10–20% of children and adolescents experience clinically significant anxiety at some point in development. Left untreated, childhood anxiety strongly predicts adult anxiety, depression, and substance use problems. Treated effectively, children with anxiety develop resilience that serves them throughout their lives.

The evidence-based treatment for childhood anxiety is CBT-based exposure — a graduated process of engaging with feared situations with support, rather than avoiding them. This approach has strong evidence, produces lasting results, and is the standard recommendation.

"Childhood anxiety responds extremely well to the right treatment."

The Parent's Role in Anxiety Treatment

Parents are the most powerful factor in whether childhood anxiety improves or worsens.

Accommodation vs. Support

The most common parental response to an anxious child — removing the feared situation, reassuring extensively, accommodating avoidance — is driven by love and makes anxiety worse. Accommodation reinforces the message that the feared situation is dangerous and the child cannot cope.

The SPACE program (Supportive Parenting for Anxious Childhood Emotions), developed at Yale, addresses parental accommodation directly and has demonstrated that treating parents' accommodating behavior produces significant improvement in childhood anxiety — sometimes without treating the child directly.

"Reducing accommodation is one of the most powerful things a parent can do for an anxious child."

The Anxious Child at School

School is often both the primary anxiety trigger and the primary avoidance target for anxious children.

School Refusal

School refusal — refusing to attend or having significant difficulty attending school due to emotional distress — is one of the most challenging presentations of childhood anxiety, requiring coordinated approach between parents, school, and mental health providers.

The principle is consistent with anxiety treatment generally: graduated reengagement, not prolonged avoidance. Extended absence from school reinforces anxiety and creates additional social and academic deficits that compound the original problem.

"School refusal requires early, consistent intervention. Avoidance makes it worse."

What Anxious Kids Need to Hear

The words matter as much as the actions.

Helpful vs. Unhelpful Responses

Unhelpful: 'Don't worry' (dismisses), 'Nothing is going to happen' (promises you can't keep), 'That's silly to be scared of' (shames).

Helpful: 'I can see this feels really scary for you' (validates), 'I know you can handle this' (communicates confidence), 'Let's take a breath together' (co-regulates), 'You've done hard things before' (builds on evidence of coping).

*"Validation and confidence communicate:
your feeling is real AND you can handle it."*

Handling Reassurance Seeking

Excessive reassurance seeking is both a symptom of anxiety and a maintaining factor.

Breaking the Reassurance Loop

Reassurance provides momentary relief and long-term reinforcement of the anxiety. Each reassurance confirms that the danger required managing and that the child couldn't tolerate the uncertainty without help.

Gradual reassurance fading — reducing the amount and frequency of reassurance given while maintaining warmth — is part of effective anxiety treatment. This requires consultation with a professional to implement well, as it can temporarily increase distress before decreasing it.

"Less reassurance, maintained warmth — the counterintuitive path to less anxious children."

When to Get Professional Help

Some anxiety is beyond parent management alone.

The Indicators

Seek professional evaluation when: anxiety is significantly impairing functioning in more than one area (school, friendships, family), it has been persistent for more than a few months, the child is experiencing physical symptoms (stomach aches, headaches, sleep disturbance), or parental management strategies are not producing improvement.

Evidence-based treatment (CBT-based exposure) delivered by a trained child therapist has the best outcomes. Look specifically for therapists trained in exposure-based treatment, not just general talk therapy for childhood anxiety.

"When anxiety impairs function in multiple areas, professional support is not optional."
